PokerLab Phase 1 Code Reference

A future-reference guide to the current Java/Maven poker engine boilerplate

Purpose: This document explains the current Phase 1 codebase: what each class is responsible for, how the 5-card and 7-card hand evaluation works, how the CLI demo flows through the system, and what should be improved next.

Current milestone: Phase 1 - Core Poker Engine. The project understands cards, decks, poker hand categories, hand comparison, and simple heads-up Texas Hold'em showdown evaluation.

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1. High-level overview

What this codebase currently does: it provides a clean, testable foundation for a poker analysis engine. It does not yet run equity simulations or solve strategy. Instead, it builds the basic engine needed before Monte Carlo simulation, range analysis, EV tools, or CFR can work.

- Represents ranks, suits, and individual cards.
- Builds and manipulates a standard 52-card deck.
- Evaluates exactly 5-card poker hands.
- Evaluates the best 5-card hand from 5, 6, or 7 cards.
- Compares a hero hand and villain hand on a shared board.
- Provides a small command-line demo and starter unit tests.

Design principle: The most important design idea is separation of responsibilities. The card package knows only about cards and decks; the hand package knows how to rank poker hands; the showdown package combines private cards and board cards to decide a winner. This makes the code easier to test and extend.

2. Project structure

```
pokerlab-phase1/
├── pom.xml
├── README.md
├── src/main/java/com/pokerlab/
│   ├── app/
│   │   └── Main.java
│   └── core/
│       ├── card/
│       │   ├── Card.java
│       │   ├── Deck.java
│       │   ├── Rank.java
│       │   └── Suit.java
│       ├── hand/
│       │   ├── EvaluatedHand.java
│       │   ├── HandCategory.java
│       │   ├── HandEvaluator.java
│       │   └── HandRank.java
│       └── showdown/
│           ├── Showdown.java
│           ├── ShowdownResult.java
│           └── Winner.java
└── src/test/java/com/pokerlab/
    └── starter JUnit tests
```

Package	Purpose	Main files
com.pokerlab.app	Small command-line entry point used to manually run a sample showdown.	Main.java
com.pokerlab.core.card	Basic poker primitives: cards, ranks, suits, and a deck.	Card, Rank, Suit, Deck
com.pokerlab.core.hand	Poker hand categories, ranking, comparison, and evaluation logic.	HandCategory, HandRank, EvaluatedHand, HandEvaluator
com.pokerlab.core.showdown	Heads-up Hold'em comparison between hero and villain on a shared board.	Showdown, ShowdownResult, Winner
src/test	Unit tests that protect basic behaviour from breaking as the project grows.	CardTest, DeckTest, HandEvaluatorTest, ShowdownTest

3. Build and run configuration

3.1 pom.xml

pom.xml is the Maven project configuration file. Maven uses it to know the project name, Java version, dependencies, and plugins.

Setting	Current value	Meaning
groupId	com.pokerlab	The organisation/package-style identifier for the project.
artifactId	pokerlab-phase1	The build artifact name.
version	1.0.0-SNAPSHOT	A development version; SNAPSHOT means it is still changing.
Java version	17	The code is compiled using Java 17 language features.
JUnit Jupiter	5.10.2	Test framework used for unit tests.

Setting	Current value	Meaning
maven-surefire-plugin	3.2.5	Runs JUnit tests when you execute mvn test.
exec-maven-plugin	3.1.0	Runs the CLI app with mvn exec:java.

```
# Run all unit tests
mvn test

# Run the sample command-line demo
mvn exec:java

# Run with custom hero, villain, and board cards
mvn exec:java -Dexec.args="AsKs QdQc Ah7c2s9dJc"
```

Card notation: The current CLI expects compact two-character notation: As = Ace of spades, Qd = Queen of diamonds, Tc = Ten of clubs. Ten is written as T rather than 10.

4. Core card package

This package contains the lowest-level building blocks. These classes should stay simple because everything else depends on them.

Class	Type	Responsibility
Rank	enum	Stores the 13 card ranks from Two to Ace, including both display symbol and numeric value.
Suit	enum	Stores the 4 suits and their compact/display symbols.
Card	record	Immutable pair of rank and suit. Can parse compact two-character notation such as A-suited-spades style input (As) or Qd.
Deck	class	Mutable standard 52-card deck with shuffle, deal, remove, and copy methods.

4.1 Rank.java

Rank is an enum. An enum is useful here because there are only 13 possible ranks. Each rank stores two pieces of data:

- symbol: the compact character used for input/output, e.g. A, K, Q, J, T, 9.
- value: the numeric strength used by the evaluator, where Two = 2 and Ace = 14.

```
ACE  -> symbol A, value 14
TEN  -> symbol T, value 10
TWO  -> symbol 2, value 2
```

fromChar(char value) turns user input into a Rank. It uppercases the input first, so both a and A would work for ace.

4.2 Suit.java

Suit is another enum. It stores:

- symbol: compact input form, e.g. s, h, d, c.
- displaySymbol: nicer output form, e.g. ♠, ♥, ♦, ♣.

```
SPADES   -> compact s, display ♠
HEARTS   -> compact h, display ♥
DIAMONDS -> compact d, display ♦
CLUBS    -> compact c, display ♣
```

fromChar(char value) lowercases the input, so S and s both parse as spades.

4.3 Card.java

Card is a Java record:

```
public record Card(Rank rank, Suit suit)
```

Why a record works well here: a card is just immutable data. Once a Card is created, its rank and suit should not change. Records also automatically provide equals, hashCode, and accessors such as rank() and suit().

Method	Purpose
Card.of(Rank rank, Suit suit)	Convenience factory method for creating a card.
Card.parse(String text)	Parses compact notation such as As, Qd, Tc.
compact()	Returns compact notation such as As.
toString()	Returns display notation such as A♠.

```
Card card = Card.parse("As");
card.rank();     // ACE
card.suit();     // SPADES
card.compact();  // "As"
card.toString(); // "A♠"
```

Input rule: Card.parse intentionally rejects 10s because the project uses T for ten. This keeps every card exactly two characters long, which makes parsing a string like AsKs easy.

4.4 Deck.java

Deck creates a standard 52-card deck in its constructor by looping through every suit and every rank.

```
for (Suit suit : Suit.values()) {
    for (Rank rank : Rank.values()) {
        cards.add(Card.of(rank, suit));
    }
}
```

Method	What it does	Important detail
size()	Returns number of cards left.	Useful for tests and simulation loops.
isEmpty()	Checks whether the deck has no cards left.	Used before dealing or in future simulations.
shuffle()	Randomly shuffles the deck.	Uses Java's default randomness.

Method	What it does	Important detail
shuffle(Random random)	Shuffles with a supplied Random object.	Useful for repeatable tests and reproducible simulations.
deal()	Removes and returns one card.	Deals from the end of the internal list.
deal(int count)	Deals multiple cards.	Validates that count is non-negative and not larger than the deck.
remove(Card card)	Removes a known card.	Will be useful in Phase 2 when hero/villain/board cards must be removed before simulation.
cards()	Returns a defensive copy.	Outside code cannot directly mutate the deck list.

Mutability: Deck is intentionally mutable. Dealing a card changes the deck. Card is immutable, but Deck represents changing state.

5. Hand evaluation package

This is the most important package in Phase 1. It decides what a poker hand is and how two poker hands compare.

Class	Type	Responsibility
HandCategory	enum	Names every poker hand category and assigns a strength value.
HandRank	record	Stores category plus tiebreaker values; implements comparison.
EvaluatedHand	record	Stores the HandRank and the actual 5 cards used.
HandEvaluator	utility class	Contains evaluateFive and evaluateBest logic.

5.1 HandCategory.java

HandCategory lists the poker hand types from weakest to strongest. Each category has a numeric strength.

Category	Strength	Meaning
HIGH_CARD	0	No pair, no straight, no flush.
ONE_PAIR	1	Two cards of the same rank.
TWO_PAIR	2	Two separate pairs.
THREE_OF_A_KIND	3	Three cards of the same rank.
STRAIGHT	4	Five consecutive ranks.
FLUSH	5	Five cards of the same suit.
FULL_HOUSE	6	Three of a kind plus a pair.
FOUR_OF_A_KIND	7	Four cards of the same rank.
STRAIGHT_FLUSH	8	Straight and flush together.
ROYAL_FLUSH	9	Ace-high straight flush.

5.2 HandRank.java

HandRank is the comparison object. A poker hand is not ranked only by category; it also needs tiebreakers.

```
public record HandRank(HandCategory category, List<Integer> tiebreakers)
        implements Comparable<HandRank>
```

Example hand	Category	Tiebreakers	Why
A♠ A♥ K♦ 7♣ 2♠	ONE_PAIR	[14, 13, 7, 2]	Pair of aces, then kickers K, 7, 2.
K♠ K♥ A♦ 7♣ 2♠	ONE_PAIR	[13, 14, 7, 2]	Pair of kings loses to pair of aces.
A♠ K♠ Q♠ J♠ T♠	ROYAL_FLUSH	[14]	Ace-high straight flush.
5♠ 4♦ 3♣ 2♥ A♠	STRAIGHT	[5]	Wheel straight; ace counts low, so high card is 5.

Comparison process:

1. Compare category strength first. A flush always beats a straight, regardless of high card.
2. If categories match, compare tiebreakers from left to right.
3. The first different tiebreaker decides the winner.
4. If everything matches, the hands tie.

5.3 EvaluatedHand.java

EvaluatedHand wraps the result of evaluation. It stores both the rank information and the exact cards used to make the best hand.

Field/method	Purpose
HandRank rank	The sortable category + tiebreakers.
List<Card> cards	The five cards used for that hand.
category()	Shortcut for rank.category().
compareTo(EvaluatedHand other)	Delegates comparison to HandRank.
toString()	Readable output such as One pair using [A♠, K♠, A❤️, 7♣, 2♠].

Immutability: The cards list is defensively copied using List.copyOf(cards), so other code cannot mutate the evaluated hand after it is created.

5.4 HandEvaluator.java

HandEvaluator is a final utility class with a private constructor. That means you do not create HandEvaluator objects. You simply call static methods such as HandEvaluator.evaluateFive(cards).

Public method	Input	Output	Use case
evaluateFive	Exactly 5 cards	EvaluatedHand	Classify a normal 5-card poker hand.
evaluateBest	5, 6, or 7 cards	Best EvaluatedHand	Texas Hold'em: choose best 5-card hand from hole cards + board.

5.4.1 evaluateFive: how a 5-card hand is classified

evaluateFive starts by validating the input:

- The list must not be null.
- There must be exactly 5 cards.
- There must be no duplicate cards.

Then it calculates three useful pieces of information:

Variable/concept	How it is calculated	Why it matters
flush	All suits are the same.	Needed for flush, straight flush, and royal flush.
straightHigh	Checks whether ranks form five consecutive values.	Needed for straight and straight flush.

Variable/concept	How it is calculated	Why it matters
countsByRank	Counts how many of each rank are present.	Needed for pairs, trips, full house, and quads.
groups	Ranks sorted by count first, then rank value.	Makes it easy to identify the most important repeated rank.
ranksDescending	All rank values sorted high to low.	Used for flush and high-card tiebreakers.

The evaluator then checks categories from strongest patterns downwards:

```
if straight and flush:
    royal flush or straight flush
else if four cards share a rank:
    four of a kind
else if three cards share a rank and two cards share another rank:
    full house
else if flush:
    flush
else if straight:
    straight
else if three cards share a rank:
    three of a kind
else if two pair ranks exist:
    two pair
else if one pair rank exists:
    one pair
else:
    high card
```

Why order matters: The exact Java code uses if statements rather than this pseudo-code, but this is the logical order. Checking stronger/special cases first avoids misclassifying a full house as only three of a kind, or a straight flush as only a straight.

5.4.2 Tiebreakers used by each category

Category	Tiebreaker list
ROYAL_FLUSH	[14]
STRAIGHT_FLUSH	[straight high card]
FOUR_OF_A_KIND	[quad rank, kicker]
FULL_HOUSE	[trip rank, pair rank]
FLUSH	[all five ranks descending]
STRAIGHT	[straight high card]
THREE_OF_A_KIND	[trip rank, highest kicker, second kicker]
TWO_PAIR	[higher pair, lower pair, kicker]
ONE_PAIR	[pair rank, highest kicker, second kicker, third kicker]
HIGH_CARD	[all five ranks descending]

5.4.3 Straight detection and the wheel straight

straightHighCard returns null if the cards are not a straight. If they are a straight, it returns the high card value.

```
A K Q J T -> straightHigh = 14
9 8 7 6 5 -> straightHigh = 9
A 5 4 3 2 -> straightHigh = 5
```

Important poker rule: The A-2-3-4-5 straight is called the wheel. Although Ace normally has value 14, it is treated as low in this one special case, so the straight high card is 5.

5.4.4 evaluateBest: how 7-card Hold'em evaluation works

evaluateBest accepts 5, 6, or 7 cards. For Texas Hold'em, a player can have 2 hole cards plus up to 5 board cards, so there are usually 7 cards available at showdown.

Simple Phase 1 strategy: generate every possible 5-card combination, evaluate each one using evaluateFive, and keep the best result.

```
7 cards choose 5 = 21 possible 5-card hands

For each 5-card candidate:
    evaluated = evaluateFive(candidate)
    if best is null or evaluated beats current best:
        best = evaluated

return best
```

Why this is good for Phase 1: it is easy to understand, hard to get wrong, and fast enough for early development. Later, if Monte Carlo simulations need more speed, this can be replaced or supplemented with bit masks, lookup tables, or cached results.

5.4.5 Validation helpers

Helper	Purpose
validateCardCount(cards, min, max)	Rejects null lists and wrong card counts.
validateNoDuplicates(cards)	Rejects duplicate cards because the same physical card cannot appear twice.
isFlush(cards)	Checks whether all cards have the same suit.
join(first, rest)	Builds a tiebreaker list such as [pair rank, kicker1, kicker2, kicker3].

6. Showdown package

The showdown package connects the evaluator to a poker situation: hero has 2 private cards, villain has 2 private cards, and both share the same board.

Class	Type	Responsibility
Winner	enum	Represents HERO, VILLAIN, or TIE.
ShowdownResult	record	Stores hero evaluated hand, villain evaluated hand, and winner.
Showdown	utility class	Validates a heads-up board and compares both players.

6.1 Showdown.java

Showdown.compare(heroHoleCards, villainHoleCards, boardCards) is the main method.

1. Validate hero has exactly 2 hole cards.
2. Validate villain has exactly 2 hole cards.
3. Validate board has between 3 and 5 cards.
4. Combine all cards and check for duplicates.
5. Build heroCards = hero hole cards + board.
6. Build villainCards = villain hole cards + board.
7. Evaluate each player's best hand using HandEvaluator.evaluateBest.
8. Compare the two evaluated hands.
9. Return ShowdownResult with the winner.

```
EvaluatedHand heroBest = HandEvaluator.evaluateBest(heroCards);
EvaluatedHand villainBest = HandEvaluator.evaluateBest(villainCards);

int comparison = heroBest.compareTo(villainBest);
Winner winner = comparison > 0 ? Winner.HERO
              : comparison < 0 ? Winner.VILLAIN
              : Winner.TIE;
```

Board size: Allowing board size between 3 and 5 means the same method can compare hands on the flop, turn, or river. At 3 or 4 board cards, evaluateBest checks the best hand from 5 or 6 total cards.

6.2 ShowdownResult.java and Winner.java

ShowdownResult is just a clean return object. Instead of returning only HERO or VILLAIN, it also stores both evaluated hands so the UI/CLI can explain why someone won.

```
public record ShowdownResult(
    EvaluatedHand heroHand,
    EvaluatedHand villainHand,
    Winner winner
)
```

Winner is intentionally simple:

```
public enum Winner {
    HERO,
    VILLAIN,
    TIE
}
```

7. CLI application flow

The CLI app is not the final product. It is a simple way to prove the engine works before building a UI or Phase 2 simulator.

Part	Explanation
main(String[] args)	Entry point when the program runs.
args.length == 3	User supplied hero, villain, and board strings.
else branch	Runs a default sample showdown if no arguments are provided.
parseCards	Converts a compact string such as AsKs into a List<Card>.
Showdown.compare	Runs the actual poker comparison.
System.out.println	Prints the inputs, both best hands, and the winner.

```
# Default sample
mvn exec:java

# Custom example
mvn exec:java -Dexec.args="AsKs QdQc Ah7c2s9dJc"
```

The compact input strings are split every two characters. For example, AsKs becomes As and Ks. Each two-character chunk is passed into Card.parse.

```
for (int i = 0; i < cleaned.length(); i += 2) {
    cards.add(Card.parse(cleaned.substring(i, i + 2)));
}
```

8. Tests currently included

The test suite is small, but it already protects the most important early behaviours. These tests should be expanded heavily before moving into Phase 2.

Test class	What it checks
CardTest	Card parsing works for compact notation; invalid notation is rejected.
DeckTest	A new deck contains 52 unique cards; dealing cards reduces deck size.
HandEvaluatorTest	Recognises royal flush, wheel straight, category comparison, and best 5 from 7.
ShowdownTest	Hero pair of aces beats villain pair of queens in the sample Hold'em scenario.

Most important test to understand: the evaluator test that checks best 5 from 7 proves the nested-combination approach works for Hold'em-style evaluation.

```
EvaluatedHand best = HandEvaluator.evaluateBest(
    cards("As", "Ks", "Qs", "Js", "Ts", "2d", "3c")
);

assertEquals(HandCategory.ROYAL_FLUSH, best.category());
assertEquals(5, best.cards().size());
```

9. End-to-end example

Input: Hero has A♠ K♠, villain has Q♦ Q♣, and the board is A♥ 7♣ 2♠ 9♦ J♣.

```
mvn exec:java -Dexec.args="AsKs QdQc Ah7c2s9dJc"
```

Step	What happens
1	Main receives three strings: AsKs, QdQc, Ah7c2s9dJc.
2	parseCards converts them into List<Card> objects.
3	Showdown.compare validates card counts and duplicate cards.
4	Hero cards become A♠ K♠ + board.
5	Villain cards become Q♦ Q♣ + board.
6	HandEvaluator.evaluateBest checks each player's best 5-card hand.
7	Hero's best category is ONE_PAIR: pair of aces.
8	Villain's best category is ONE_PAIR: pair of queens.
9	HandRank comparison sees pair rank 14 beats pair rank 12.
10	Winner is HERO.

Why this example matters: This example is useful as a sanity check because both players have the same hand category. The result depends on tiebreakers, not just category strength.

10. Current limitations and improvement checklist

This is a good Phase 1 baseline, but it is still early-stage code. These are the most important next improvements.

Area	Current limitation	Recommended improvement
CLI validation	It checks string length, but error messages are still basic.	Add friendlier messages and examples when input fails.
Duplicate reporting	HandEvaluator reports counts map for duplicates; Showdown only gives a general message.	Report exactly which card was duplicated.
Test coverage	Only a few hand categories are tested.	Add tests for every category and edge-case comparisons.
Performance	7-card evaluation brute-forces all combinations.	Keep for now, then benchmark before optimising.
Card ordering	EvaluatedHand stores cards in the candidate order, not necessarily pretty sorted order.	Optionally sort display cards by relevance for nicer output.
Range support	No poker range parser yet.	Add in Phase 3 after equity simulation basics.
Simulation	No Monte Carlo engine yet.	Phase 2 should add a simulator that removes known cards from the deck and samples unknown boards.
UI	Only CLI output exists.	Add UI only after the engine and tests are stronger.

11. Phase 2 preparation notes

Why Phase 1 matters for Phase 2: a Monte Carlo equity simulator repeatedly deals random unknown cards and uses the evaluator to decide who wins. Therefore, Card, Deck, HandEvaluator, and Showdown are the core dependencies for the next stage.

Phase 2 feature	Phase 1 code it will reuse
Hand-vs-hand equity	Card.parse, Deck.remove, Deck.shuffle, Deck.deal, Showdown.compare
Random board completion	Deck after known cards have been removed.
Win/tie/loss counting	Winner enum from ShowdownResult.
Equity formula	wins, ties, and simulation count collected around Showdown.compare.
Reproducible simulations	Deck.shuffle(Random random) for deterministic test seeds.

```
future Monte Carlo loop idea:

known cards = hero + villain + partial board
for simulation in 1..N:
    deck = new Deck()
    remove all known cards from deck
    shuffle deck
    complete board to 5 cards
    result = Showdown.compare(hero, villain, completedBoard)
    count hero wins, villain wins, ties
```

Engineering advice: Do not optimise the hand evaluator before measuring performance. First, build the simulator with the clear evaluator, write tests, then benchmark. Only optimise if the runtime is actually a problem.

Appendix A: Quick class responsibility summary

File	One-sentence description
Main.java	Parses CLI input, runs a showdown, and prints the result.
Card.java	Immutable rank+suit object with compact parsing and display output.
Rank.java	Enum for ranks Two through Ace, including numeric strength.
Suit.java	Enum for clubs, diamonds, hearts, spades, including display symbols.
Deck.java	Mutable 52-card deck with shuffle, deal, remove, and copy behaviour.
HandCategory.java	Ordered list of poker hand categories from high card to royal flush.
HandRank.java	Comparable category + tiebreakers object used to decide which hand is stronger.
EvaluatedHand.java	The evaluated result: hand rank plus the five cards used.
HandEvaluator.java	Core logic for classifying 5-card hands and choosing best 5 from 7.
Showdown.java	Combines hole cards with board cards and compares hero vs villain.
ShowdownResult.java	Return object containing both evaluated hands and the winner.
Winner.java	Enum representing HERO, VILLAIN, or TIE.

Appendix B: Suggested immediate next coding tasks

- Add evaluator tests for every category: high card, pair, two pair, trips, straight, flush, full house, quads, straight flush, royal flush.
- Add comparison tests for tricky tiebreakers: pair vs pair, two pair vs two pair, flush vs flush, full house vs full house.
- Add duplicate-card tests for Showdown.compare and HandEvaluator.evaluateBest.
- Add a small EquityResult record in preparation for Phase 2.
- Build a MonteCarloSimulator class that supports fixed hero/villain hands and unknown board completion.
- Keep the CLI simple for now; the core engine is more important than UI polish at this stage.

Code review confirmation

The project owner reviewed the code changes in the revision below and explicitly cleared PR creation on 2026-11-03 (Europe/London).

Reviewed code commit

`b7db0595f4c714c4d71491246a33bf4011751eea`

Branch: codex/minimum-preflop-api

Clearance message: cleared b7db059

This confirmation applies to the code changes in that revision. It does not assert review of the entire historical codebase or later changes. Further material code changes require renewed review.

The project Code Review History records the approval and validation context.